diverse interests. Traditionally, India's approach to the region has been based on safeguarding three issues of interest. This required India to maintain a careful balancing act between Israel, Iran, and the Gulf Arab states (including Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Qatar, Oman and others).

The first long-standing interest for India has been energy imports. India has been among the major economies most dependent on the region's oil and gas production. Oil was traditionally sourced from a variety of partners, including Iraq, Saudi Arabia, Kuwait, and the UAE. Qatar has emerged as a major natural gas provider, particularly after international sanctions on Iran led to an Indian reduction in imports from that country.

A second major preoccupation has involved the large Indian diaspora, primarily in the Gulf Arab states, from whom India receives significant remittances. There are over ten million Indian citizens in the Gulf and that number is only growing. The safety and security of Indian citizens in West Asia has required the Indian government to evacuate Indian nationals from the region in the event of conflicts, including from Iraq and Kuwait in 1990, from Lebanon in 2006, from Libya in 2011, from Yemen in 2015, and from Israel in 2023.

Third, India has developed important security relationships, particularly defence imports from Israel and intelligence cooperation with a variety of partners. After normalizing relations in the early 1990s, India and Israel developed a low-profile but cost-effective defence industrial relationship that involved sales of critical military supplies, upgrading older military platforms, and some nascent joint production. In time, India grew into one of the largest export destinations for Israel's defence industry. But India has vital security interests in the region beyond defence cooperation with Israel. This extends to intelligence cooperation with the United Arab Emirates and Saudi Arabia, coordination on Afghanistan with Iran, and port access and logistical cooperation with Oman.

Although diaspora, energy, and security have been the three major pillars of India's West Asian engagement, new opportunities have rapidly opened up. With Israel, for example, economic links have expanded to cover pharmaceuticals, technology, tourism, infrastructure, and especially